

Voice and Tone

To brush up on these concepts, think of **voice** as being similar to your personality. Everyone has a different one, informed by their experiences. Some are very unique, others are less memorable. We want to aim for the former.

Tone is the way voice fluctuates depending on the situation. How you express yourself in an exciting situation probably sounds different from how you would approach solving a complicated problem, but the voice remains the same.

Think of it this way: when I was a child back in the eighties, the evenings felt hectic. My siblings and I would be watching tv, playing video games or generally being loud while my mother would be just home from work, trying to pull things together for a meal in the kitchen. She would be telling us to be quiet in a very specific tone of voice.

But! Then the phone would ring, and since ours was in the kitchen (yes, I'm speaking of [landline](#) phones) my mom would be the closest to answer it, and when she did, it was always in a very different type of tone, that felt more pleasing and warm than the one she had been using to tell us to be quiet (and probably rightfully). Her voice stayed the same, but how she expressed herself (tone) changed in the two situations.

Chances are that we won't be answering the phone a lot in our work, but I think this illustration is helpful in understanding the importance of the consistency of the voice, or messaging, as it is applied to different situations, such as writing copy for events, or a website, or a social media post.

The Fastly Voice

"The voice should sound like the embodiment of a cool person you meet at the airport who has interesting stories, and fills you in the details to bring you along, and shares the big cool thing they are traveling toward next..."

The Fastly voice is:

- **Straight-forward:** Aim for clarity of thought instead of comprehensive details, and concise use of language over lengthy, unnecessary phrases or acronyms
- **Friendly:** As in, easy to talk to. A person who is warm, kind, welcoming and reassuring. Assumes you are just as curious as they are.
- **Knowledgeable:** Confident, but never braggy. An expert who wants you to avoid making the same mistakes they did.

For a clearer picture, think of your favorite teacher, or if you didn't have one, someone who served as a trusted advisor. We want to sound like someone who people trust, who makes them feel supported, comfortable and reassured that we can help guide them.

Usage and Styling Tips

We write with the following in mind:

- **Plain-English:** As an inclusive brand and community, we want to welcome both traditional and non-traditional builders. Idioms, jargon, and industry-insider terms should be avoided.
- **Clarity:** We are speaking to a global audience, so our words should be clear and concise, with no room for confusion or misunderstanding.
- **Personality:** Even if we're talking about code, there should be a human aspect expressed along the way.
- **POV:** We use the first person plural perspective ("we") when speaking about Fastly and the community because we are always in collaboration; when speaking specifically to the reader, we use second person perspective ("you").
 - *Note: When writing as Fastly, we always use "we;" however, if a team member writes a blog, for example, from their own perspective, they can use "I" as their first person perspective.*
- **Active Voice:** If we seek to engage and get others to participate, there's an energy and optimism that should always be coursing through our words.
- **Community-focused:** We filter our perspective through the lens of the individual creators, highlighting how product changes serve the community.
- **Emphasis on the good:** We're a positive brand that always wants to highlight opportunities and what's possible, even if something's gone wrong.
- **Long-term:** Think of communication on a long-term scale; we want our communications and resources to age well.

Practical Examples

All of the messaging that we create should have, or be created with, a **specific goal in mind**. What are the goals of your messaging?